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CHILDHOOD AND SOCIALISATION

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2.1 INTRODUCTION

Socialisation is a process of shaping children's behaviour, values and beliefs within the family context. It involves the interaction between parents and children wherein parents provide support, guidance and control to help children internalize societal norms and develop a positive sense of self. The quality of parent-child interaction plays a crucial role in the effective socialisation

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process. Social learning starts from infancy and continues throughout life, shaping personality, attitudes and behaviour. It is a network of people and their relationship with one another that fosters a sense of belongingness, social cohesion, cooperation and positive social environment. It also provides a platform for shaping the life of individuals to learn, grow and reach their full potential. Socialisation is an important process for functioning and continuation of society. It is the mode of learning to live in a society. Socialisation basically is the learning of social values and how to control and regulate them.

**2.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner

- comprehends the meaning and process of socialisation;
- analyses the impacts of parenting, family and child rearing on child development;
- evaluates the effect of child labour, abuse and poverty on children;
- describes the role of peers, school culture and teachers in shaping socialisation.

2.3 MEANING OF SOCIALISATION

Socialisation is the lifelong process that begins with childhood and continues throughout life. Through this process, individuals learn and internalise social norms, beliefs, values, habits, culture and behavioural patterns of their society. It facilitates the development of personality, behaviour and interaction skills necessary for effective participation in society. In the process of socialisation, one generation transfers its knowledge to the next, to foster self-awareness and encourage active engagement in social phenomena and contributions to the social order. Thus, socialization refers to the process of social influence through which a person acquires the culture of their group, and in the course of acquiring these cultural elements, the individual's self and personality are shaped. Definitions according to some of the social thinkers are as follows:

Socialisation refers to the process through which a dependent infant develops into a self-aware and informed individual, adapt in the cultural practices and norms of their society (Giddens, 1979).

Socialisation is the process of acquiring knowledge and skills that equip



individuals to fulfill their roles within society (Johnson, 1960).

Socialisation involves a multifaceted process of interaction where individuals develop the habits, skills, beliefs, and judgment needed to actively engage in social groups and communities (Lundberg, 1939).

Socialisation refers to the fostering of a collective sense of unity among individuals, enhancing their ability and willingness to collaborate effectively (Ross, 1908).

2.4 IMPORTANCE OF SOCIALISATION

Socialisation is essential for every individual living in society and makes it possible for individuals to fully function as human beings. Socialisation enables a person to acquire social abilities which comprises skills necessary to interact, empathize, cooperate and participate in society. Social interaction is essential for Socialisation. Without Socialisation, we could not have our society and culture. Social interaction at various levels helps individuals behave appropriately in and outside the home. Behavioural patterns include greeting styles, dress codes for different occasions, communication and social language usage.

Cognitive development occurs through interaction with various agents. Individuals gain knowledge and skills that nurture cognitive growth, expand thinking abilities, problem solving and understanding of the world. Learning through observation and imitation enhances the development of the cognitive sphere.

Emotional development refers to the ability to understand and regulate one's emotions effectively as well as empathise with others. It begins with interaction within the family, relatives, peers, neighbours, and social institutions. It helps to create and sustain relationships with family and other members. It empowers individuals to express, recognize, and manage their own emotions and react appropriately to the emotions of other people as well.

Social development is the process of learning social norms, beliefs, values, knowledge and skills needed to adapt and function in society. Individuals learn social skills to deal with day-to-day challenges. It is acquired through natural interaction within their environment, primarily at home and educational institutions. Individuals acquire communication, listening skills, eye contact, initiation, signals, symbols, language, use of social cues and other interpersonal

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skills required to attain success socially.

Moral development refers to the state where individuals can differentiate between right and wrong. It evolves across different stages of life, in different ways. Understanding of moral values such as honesty, empathy, fairness and justice begins with family and extends to the wider world. Development of morality is crucial for individuals to establish well in the social scenario.

Spiritual development is the exploration of inner self and values. In the process of Socialisation, family, peers, and social groups influence their beliefs and practices. Religious practices followed by family members shape their spiritual understanding. Practices such as prayer and meditation aid in cognitive, emotional and social development and provide a space for exploration and self-awareness which initiates reconsideration of societal norms and values.

2.5 TYPES OF SOCIALISATION

Primary Socialisation is the initial phase of Socialisation which provides foundation for life. In this phase, individuals learn basic values, norms, culture, attitudes and behaviour patterns from parents, relatives and community. It takes place in natural settings, through informal education. Family plays an important role in the process of socialisation because of spending most of the time with family members such as mother, father, sister and brother. In the process of Socialisation, individuals learn through the interaction by imitation, observation and experiences.

Secondary Socialisation begins with formal education through small groups and institutions where individuals learn to behave appropriately outside the family. Here individuals acquire new norms, values, culture, attitude and behavioural patterns required for broader social integration. School and peer groups play an important role in the secondary phase of Socialisation where an individual learns new culture and norms. School is a place where individuals interact with other members of society beyond their family members. The mode of Socialisation is situational and slightly differs from their home. For proper interaction with other stakeholders of the school, temperament of adaptability and requisite social considerations are essential. Schools provide democratic environment for inculcating democratic norms for better adjustment in the outer world.

Resocialisation is the process of adaptability to use learned norms, values,

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culture and attitudes in new organisations as per assigned roles and requirements. In this phase, discarding some previously learned experiences and adapting new norms take place. Resocialisation occurs when someone's values and beliefs change drastically. Goffman (1961) described "total institution" as places of residence and work where a large number of similarly situated individuals are cut off from the wider society for an extended period, leading to an enclosed, formerly administered life. ReSocialisation is a process where an individual must follow the new norms and values of an unfamiliar environment where previously learned behaviour patterns have no use. In a prison system, you have to unlearn the previous custom and learn new behaviour patterns. An individual isolated from society and forced to follow new customs.

Anticipatory Socialisation occurs when individuals prepare for future roles by learning new norms, customs, values, attitudes and behavioural patterns expected in those roles. In the first phase of socialisation, parents and family prepare children for formal education and in the second phase schools prepare children for higher responsibilities. Robert K. Merton (1957) introduced the term anticipatory Socialisation. Anticipatory Socialisation describes the process by which an individual learns the norms, standards and behaviour patterns of the new group they wish to join. It involves a change in the person's attitude and behaviour in order to prepare for joining a targeted group. A student of drama school behaves like an actor.

2.6 ROLE OF PARENTING, FAMILY AND CHILD REARING IN SOCIALISATION

Parenting

Parents play a crucial role in the process of socialisation as the child spends maximum time with them. In the beginning parents support their children in learning basic practices of life. Gradually they continue their efforts to make them self-reliant and responsible citizens of the society. Parents also make them aware of what is wrong and right behaviour in social life. Parenting is quite effective in the process of shaping behaviour due to emotional bonding with parents.

Family

Family is the first and most influential unit in personality development. Parents, siblings, grandparents and extended family members shape child's character or



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entire personality. Thus it can be said that family plays a crucial role in the process of socialisation. A child learns a behaviour pattern through observation of the conduct of family members. A child also learns how to develop relationships with others and maintain it.

Child rearing encompasses the methods and practices used in raising children greatly influencing their emotional, moral and social development. Child rearing motive to make child a successful member of the society, having knowledge of necessary social skills, behaviour patterns, norms and values. The style of parenting influences a lot the socialisation process and context. Time spent on child rearing is one of the key factors to imparting the social values for expected behaviour patterns.

2.7 SOCIALISATION AND EDUCATION

Socialisation and Education are intertwined and essential for holistic development of the individuals. They ensure the inclusion of individuals in various social and cultural scenarios to develop their social skills. Education articulates the importance of socialisation and socialisation supports education as an important element for holistic development. A child passes through various stages of Socialisation in his/her entire life. Socialisation influences personality development especially during childhood with various elements playing vital roles at different stages.

2.8 AGENTS OF SOCIALISATION

Anyone who surrounds the child and affects the child's personality is known as socialisation agents. These include friends, peers, classmates, neighbours, mass media and institutions etc. Some important agents' roles are discussed below:

Peer Groups have significant impact in the process of socialisation. It refers to a group who have similar interests, age, background and social status. In childhood, individuals spend sufficient time and interact more with their peers. These interactions during childhood heavily influence behaviour, thoughts, actions and decision- making, both directly and indirectly. Peer groups become the essential part of individuals' life where they get the opportunity to develop their unique identity by engaging themselves in different activities. This group highly influences personality in adolescence, in which they share their ideas freely, mostly from other members.

School Culture is another important unit of socialisation. Schools act as a

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miniature of the society, bringing together children from diverse backgrounds. They provide structured environments where individuals learn social skills, values, behaviour patterns and norms through the curricular and co-curricular activities. These experiences help individuals develop their identity and enable them to play their roles in society effectively. Schools guide children how to behave in society and teachers act as role models of society. Some of the moral practices are developed through hidden curriculum which is quite necessary for the better adjustment in their surroundings. Schools are promoting good behaviours among children by rewarding them for their actions.

Mass Media is another powerful agent of socialisation. Mass media, as an agent of socialisation, influences individuals' understanding of the world and shapes their values and behaviour. It acts as a powerful force in transmitting cultural norms, social expectations contributing to the socialisation process. The role of mass media as an influencer of behaviour enables educators to develop educational broadcasts such as radio lessons, television lessons, and educational web pages. However, socialisation promoted by mass media is indirect and takes a short time for adjusted behaviour to be manifested. Nowadays role of multimedia devices is increasing in everyone's life for communication purpose with the help of electronic media (TVs, Radio, Computer), print media (Newspaper, magazines, books), videogames, internet, mobile connection, and digital platform such as social media platform WhatsApp, Face Book, Instagram, X etc foster peer interaction, influence group norms and impact identity development and help individuals to gain knowledge in various areas to provide a wider scope of learning new experiences.

2.9 ROLE OF SCHOOLS IN SOCIALISATION

Fostering a healthy environment: Schools are places where a child gets the opportunity to learn new things which could not be possible in home space. In organizing various activities, schools provide scope of self-expression, and chance of maintaining friendship with others. In schools' setting, some different patterns of behaviour followed by children develop a sense of understanding that home and schools have different norms at some level.

Promoting empathy and compassion: In the process of socialisation, children interact with others and share their experience with each other. Such kind of sharing activities make them aware of the other's experiences which helps to develop empathy and compassion among children. They can easily assume the



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thoughts and feelings of another person.

Encouraging social skills through curriculum: A comprehensive curriculum always supports the development of various skills among students by incorporating different topics and components in the syllabus. Schools provide opportunities for discussion on various issues, assign projects in groups and collaborative activities for their students' overall development which helps them to adjust in different societies in future.

Proper guidance and counselling: It plays an essential role to develop personal and social skills in students to manage their personal and social life. In the schools, students have different backgrounds in social, economic, cultural and religious contexts where various challenges are faced by the individuals such as peer pressure, conflict on particular issues and family problems. Counsellors support to understand the self and maintain healthy relationship and emotional management in different situations. In this process, an individual shares feelings to the counsellor and counsellor provides support to come out of the troubling situation and enable him to deal with such kind of situation in life.

Celebrating festivals is a path to foster a deeper sense of cultural diversity through engagement of students in various practices of customs and rituals. In the process of celebration, students develop cross-cultural understanding and learn to respect the differences and feel the beauty of diverse cultures. It's a way of inclusive social interaction for inculcating unity, fraternity and community bonding. Such kinds of activities build strong connections with other students and teachers and increase the rational thinking among students to enhance positive attitude in every aspect of life with moral values.

2.10 ROLE OF TEACHERS AS FACILITATORS AND ACTIVE CONSTRUCTORS OF KNOWLEDGE

Teachers play a vital role in the process of socialisation. Teachers are role models and facilitators of socialisation. Teachers are increasingly transitioning from being mere transmitters of knowledge to becoming facilitators and active constructors of knowledge. This paradigm shift involves empowering them to take ownership of their learning process by actively engaging with the material, questioning, exploring and constructing their understanding. With the rise of constructivist pedagogy, teachers are increasingly seen as facilitators of learning rather than mere deliverers of facts. This shift suggests that learners build their understanding of the world based on their experiences and interactions with

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others.

Encouraging peer interaction: Teacher plays an important role in the process of socialisation. In school environment, teachers perform their academic duties by transmitting knowledge through interactions. Teachers plan different strategies to achieve their goals by organizing various kinds of group activities to facilitate the process of socialisation in students and encourage their active participation with a supportive environment for their peers.

Teaching social skills: In the era of technology, the role of teachers is to develop general social skills such as communication, patience, collaboration, adaptability, and problem solving ability which are quite necessary for bridging the gap of theory and practical knowledge. Social skill helps students to make right choice in their life for getting success in career and personal life.

Promoting inclusiveness: It is a teacher's responsibility to provide an inclusive environment in classroom for every student irrespective of their different abilities, class (economic status), social status, religious and cultural background. The role of teacher has a great impact on students from diverse backgrounds. Teachers act as key agents of inclusion by fostering a welcoming and supportive environment for all students, regardless of their differences. This involves adapting teaching methods, providing differentiated instruction, and promoting positive peer relationships to ensure every student feels valued and has equal opportunities to learn and participate.

Motivation for critical thinking: In the present scenario, ability of critical thinking is an essential part of life of students where an immense source of knowledge is available. It is difficult to find authentic and valid knowledge. Ability of critical thinking prepares students for judging and making smart decisions by analysing information and understanding various aspects of knowledge. For this purpose, teachers have to provide a platform for discussion where every student has a chance to share his/her point of view rationally. This approach to teaching builds confidence in nervous and shy students and makes them think independently and increases their engagement and active participation in classroom teaching and learning.

Organising community programs: This is a significant tool of socialisation for holistic development of students. Teachers provide a space to the students for developing team spirit for working together in a collaborative manner. Activities like drama, role play, debate etc. encourage students to share their



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ideas and listen to others and involve in constructive dialogue regardless of their ability and background. Such kind of activities inculcate the initiation and leadership ability among students and builds confidence for decision making.

2.11 EVALUATE THE EFFECT OF CHILD LABOUR, ABUSE AND POVERTY ON CHILDREN SOCIALISATION

Child labour is a curse to society. Poverty is found to be the most important cause of child labour. Most of the child labourers come from poor households. For poor households, child labour often serves as a means of survival. On the one hand, as their family size is large and adult wages are significantly low, they alone cannot support the large number of dependents in the family. On the other hand, their low wages/income are also subject to fluctuations. In such situation, the survival of the families concerned is constantly at risk. In order to minimize this risk, they have to diversify the source of their household income. For this purpose, they engage their children in labour in different occupations. So, under financial constraints children are being pushed into child labour. This hampers their physical and mental development. They are deprived of education. As a result, they, once grown as adults, have to do unskilled jobs and their productivity remains low. This results in lower wages and perpetuates poverty and consequently child labour. This indicates the significant impact that poverty alleviation may have on child labour in the targeted community. Therefore, eradicating of child labour requires a multi-pronged approach focusing on prevention, enforcement and rehabilitation. Key strategies include making education accessible and compulsory, providing social safety nets, enacting and enforcing strict laws, raising awareness, and promoting ethical business practices.

Child abuse refers to the negligence and maltreatment of a child. It involves all kinds of physical, mental, emotional, social, and sexual ill-treatment and neglect. Most of the abused children have negative emotional impact. These emotional effects of child abuse have significant and lasting impact on developing severe social problems such as struggle at school, drug abuse and juvenile delinquency.

Poverty significantly impacts socialisation, affecting children's emotional well-being, cognitive development, and social skills. Children in poverty may experience increased stress, limited social opportunities, and negative impacts on self-esteem and identity formation. These factors can hinder their ability to form healthy relationships, succeed in school, and participate fully in society.



2.12 LET US SUM UP

- Socialisation is defined as the lifelong process starting in childhood during which individuals internalize social norms, beliefs, values, culture, and behavioral patterns.
- Socialisation supports comprehensive development, including cognitive growth, emotional skills, social skills, and moral understanding.
- Primary Socialisation provides the foundational learning of basic values from parents and family in informal settings. Secondary Socialisation begins later, primarily through formal education (school and peer groups), where new norms are acquired for broader social integration. Other forms include ReSocialisation (discarding old behaviors to adapt to a new setting, such as a “total institution”) and Anticipatory Socialisation (learning expectations for future roles).
- The primary agents include the family (the most influential unit for personality development), peer groups (which significantly influence behavior, identity, and thoughts during adolescence), school culture (acting as a miniature of society), and mass media (a powerful force transmitting cultural norms and expectations).
- Schools and teachers play a crucial role by fostering healthy, inclusive environments, promoting empathy, and acting as role models and facilitators who encourage social skills and critical thinking.
- This essential process can be negatively impacted by societal challenges such as Child Labour (which results from poverty and deprives children of education), Child Abuse (leading to long-lasting negative emotional effects and severe social problems), and Poverty (causing stress and limiting cognitive and social opportunities).



2.13 END EXERCISES

1. What do you mean by socialisation?
2. How does socialisation affect personality development?
3. Explain any two types of socialisation with suitable example.



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4. What do you mean by the foundational phase of socialisation?
5. Explain two main pillars of socialisation.
6. Why is child rearing an important factor in socialisation?
7. How does poverty affect the socialisation of a child? Explain it.
8. Describe the problems of child labour in Indian society.

2.14 REFERENCES

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